



white patches on chest, sides, and rump

# Tasmanian devil

*Sarcophilus harrisii*

The world's largest living carnivorous marsupial gets its name from the screeches and growls it produces during hunts for food. Tasmanian devils are predominantly scavengers, using their strong, wide jaws to devour the flesh, fur, and bone of often rotting animal carcasses. However, they will eat whatever is available, from insects to mammals, including "imps": young Tasmanian devils. Devils are equally unfussy about their habitat, provided they can find shelter during the day and food by night.

## Uncertain future

Once common throughout Australia, today the species exists only in Tasmania, where it is critically endangered in the wild due to a contagious cancer called devil facial tumor disease (DFTD), spread from animal to animal through biting—a common occurrence when devils meet. To preserve the species, a national conservation program has established a DFTD-free captive "insurance population."



## △ HIDING OUT

Young Tasmanian devils shelter in caves, hollow logs, or burrows to avoid predators such as eagles or other devils.

most powerful bite relative to body size of any animal

Tasmanian devils can **eat 40 percent of their body weight** in half an hour